

CHAPTER NINE

Carrying Too Much

This is the chapter where Ms. Calloway shows the kids the backpack. The backpack is a regular backpack — blue, with a small tear on one of the straps, because Ms. Calloway bought it at a yard sale fourteen years ago and has been using it for this lesson ever since.

"Friends," she said, "I have a backpack here. Today I am going to put things into it, while you watch."

She put the backpack on her shoulders. Empty.

"Right now," she said, "the backpack is empty. I can walk around. I can move my arms. I can do anything I want."

She walked around the front of the room. The kids watched.

"Now," she said, "I am going to put something in the backpack." She picked up a small heavy stone from her desk — she had a basket of them — and dropped it into the backpack.

"This stone," she said, "is something that happened to me. Maybe somebody said something unkind to me. Maybe I made a mistake. Maybe I am worried about something. It does not matter what it is. It is something. And I have put it in the backpack."

She walked around again. The backpack was barely heavier.

"I can still walk. I can still do most things. One stone is not a problem."

Then she put another stone in.

"Now I have two stones. Still okay."

She put another in. And another. And another. With each stone, the backpack got heavier, and Ms. Calloway moved a little slower, and her shoulders began to bend forward, just a little.

By the time she had eight stones in the backpack, she was hunched over. Her shoulders were almost touching her chest. She was walking like an old, old person.

The kids stared.

"Friends," she said, in a voice that was a little wheezy from being hunched over, "what do you think happens if I just keep walking around like this all day? All week? All year?"

"Your back would hurt," said Marcus.

"You would be tired," said Priya.

"You would not want to play," said Mia.

"You would be sad," said Maya, very quietly.

"All of those," said Ms. Calloway. "Yes. All of those things." She took the backpack off. She set it down. She stretched, and her shoulders went back to normal, and she smiled, and the kids smiled because she was Ms. Calloway again and not a hunched-over old person. "Here is what Unit Two is about," she said. "Every one of us, every single day, has the chance to put stones in our backpack. The stones are the heavy feelings we carry around after something happens. I should not have said that. I should not have done that. I made a mistake yesterday and I am still thinking about it. My friend was mad at me last week and even though we made up, I am still carrying it."

"Some stones," she said, "have to go in for a little while. That is normal. If you make a mistake, you carry a little bit of it for a little while — because that helps you fix it and remember not to do it again. Stones are not bad."

"But — and this is the important part — every stone has to come out eventually. Because if you do not take the stones out, you walk around hunched over for the rest of your life. And that does not help you. And it does not help the person you might have hurt. And it does not help anybody."

She picked up the backpack again.

"This week," she said, "I want you to think about your stones. What is in your backpack? What stones have you been carrying that you could put down? What stones are old stones, that you do not need to carry anymore?"

The kids in Room 12 went quiet.

Sofia was thinking about the apples.

Marcus was thinking about Aaliyah, and a thing he had said to her over the weekend that he had not yet told anyone about.

Maya was thinking about why she didn't live with her mom. (Maya thinks about this often. Maya has not figured out, yet, that this is a stone she did not put in her own backpack — that this stone was given to her, and that she has been carrying somebody else's stone all this time. She will figure that out later. Not in this book. Maybe in the next book. We will see.)

Priya was thinking about a spelling test. She had gotten three words wrong. The test was from two weeks ago.

The kids all had stones. Every one of them. Even Jordan, who looked like nothing ever bothered him, had a stone — though we will not find out what Jordan's stone is for a long time, because Jordan is very good at hiding stones, and one of the things he is going to learn this year, slowly, is that hiding stones is not the same as not having them.

Ms. Calloway put the backpack down at the front of the room. "That is enough thinking for today," she said. "For now —

just notice. Just notice what is in your backpack. We will figure out what to do with the stones later."

Then she gave each child, very ceremoniously, a small smooth stone from her basket. The stones were the same color and the same shape — gray-blue, smooth, the size of a small egg.

"Keep this stone," she said. "Put it in your desk. We are going to use it later. It is going to mean something."

The kids put the stones in their desks.

Theo, who is a careful and observant child, was the one who said, on the way out for recess: "I think the stones might be important." He was right.